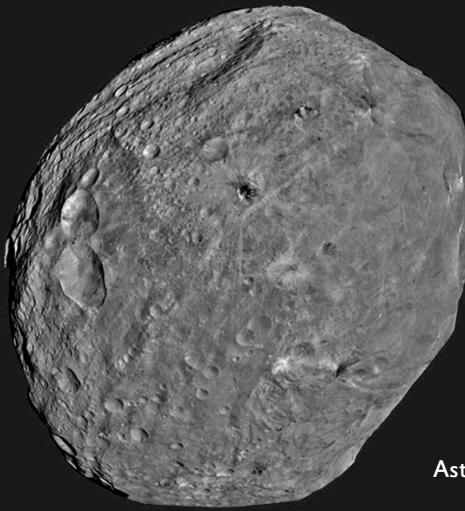




Asteroid Vesta

A real whopper

The brightest and second largest asteroid in the belt is Vesta. It has a diameter of 530 km (329 miles). Ceres is the largest and the first asteroid to be discovered. It is now also classed as a dwarf planet.

Vast in size

The asteroid belt contains millions of asteroids. Scientists estimate there are around two million with a diameter larger than 1 km (0.6 miles), and 200 larger than 100 km (60 miles).



Chicxulub Crater in Mexico

Collision course

Stray asteroids or comets occasionally collide with planets, creating huge craters. An asteroid may have crashed into the Earth 65 million years ago, causing a catastrophic climate change that wiped out the dinosaurs.

Just passing

The Galileo spacecraft took the first clear photographs of the asteroid Gaspra, when it passed through the belt en route to Jupiter in 1991. It later took a picture of Ida, which is 55 km (35 miles) long, when it passed through the asteroid belt again in 1993. The shot included Ida's moon, Dactyl – the first evidence that asteroids can have satellites of their own.

Asteroids range in size and shape. Only the largest tend to be round.

